

Better colour e-paper

Ricoh has announced colour electronic paper, which it claims is 2.5 times brighter than that of its competitors. It uses lamination techniques layering three strips of electrochromic material between two substrates.

Only 1.6 million?

Gartner states that Microsoft has sold 1.6 million units of the new Windows Phone 7 based smartphones, from among 3.6 million smartphones running the Windows operating system.

Apple iPad 2

The king of tablets

After creating a product that spawned an entire generation of mediocre clones, a second coming only expected. In fact, some are already talking about an iPad 3.0! However, for the moment, let's bask in the warm afterglow of an enjoyable product that is elegantly designed and effortlessly usable. The iPad 2 is slightly slimmer and lighter than its predecessor

but sports the same display and resolution, and the brushed aluminium unibody. It's clear that buttons and keys on the body have seen minor adjustments, probably based on feedback. Under the hood, however,

things could not be any more different, for the iPad 2 sports a dual core processor clocked at 1 GHz and a new graphic solution that Apple claims is



at least 3 times more powerful. The SoC is called the A5, and whether or not it's identical to the Samsung Exynos, Apple blokes will not say.

While tablets are a whole lot of fun to play around with, they remain just that – gimmicky. It's not really for those who want to get work done. Nothing has changed here, although with the faster hardware, movie editing and running the likes of Garage Band becomes possible. But, you can't create 3D games on it – remember we said it's for consumption, not production. Physically on account of the slimmer profile, the iPad 2 feels sturdier, and we like the perforations in the body that serve as the loudspeaker vent.

The cover fits magnetically to the iPad. The display on the iPad 2 looks slightly sharper than the previous one, and we're sure this difference is because of the smaller gap between the LCD and outer glass and the IPS panel used is the same one.

It is rigid with folds and these folds can be used to prop up the iPad in a number of ways. The iPad 2 has two cameras, a front-facing one for Facetime, and a rear one that boasts of HD video recording. Unfortunately, the resolution of the rear camera is no more for still images too, and the

we played felt jerky; Infinity Blade that had the occasional jerk on the iPad works creamily smooth. Aside from the accelerometer, the iPad 2 introduces a 3-direction gyro sensor that allows sensing of lateral and vertical movement for example, panning the tablet around.

There will be quite a few games that could utilise this extra bit of control. We tested the music playback, and found the iPad 2 a little less warm than the original iPad, in which if you recall, we found a deviation from neutral. Thankfully, this one is much closer. The loudspeaker is around 15 percent

louder. Tested battery life is actually very good – at least on par with the original iPad, and during gaming, we actually got an extra 30 minutes playing Plants And Zombies.

Criticism against the iPad 2 is scarce, other than a couple of nits. It's a great product, albeit not as revolutionary as its predecessor. Other than the hardware, and some minor cosmetic changes, very little has changed, leading us to one conclusion – this product refresh was 70 percent marketing strategy and 30 per cent about serving consumers. At an MRP ranging from ₹29,500 for the 16 GB model, to ₹46,900 for the 64 GB model with 3G support, the iPad 2 is only slightly costlier than its predecessor, but more expensive than any other tablet on the market. However, it's leagues ahead of the mob too, and makes a great, (if expensive), addition to your gadget collection.

In terms of performance, none of the apps and games

quality is quite basic – lots of grain and loss of detail, however, this inclusion is a plus for those looking out for 3G plans. During testing, many complained about the lack of a better camera, like the one on the iPhone 5. Well, Apple wants you to wait for an iPad 3 and possibly a fourth version. Can't put all your apples in one basket, right?

We tried the HDMI out accessory, but the video quality was a bit disappointing – the iPad 2 doesn't upscale well, and the picture was a bit snowy (faces and expressions were not detailed). We're hoping patches solve this. The keypad on the iPad 2 is very sensitive and usable, the only problem is it's too big to be used like a PDA, and a bit too compact to be used as a notebook keypad; still we tried our hand at typing a couple of 300 word emails with no issues.

Michael Browne

Specifications

Display: 9.7-inches, 1024 x 768 pixels; SoC: Apple A5 dual core 1 GHz; Storage: 64 GB; weight: 613 grams

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7.5/10

Features.....7.5
Performance.....8.0
Build Quality8.5
Value for money6.5